

T

THE RADIO & GRAMOPHONE House in New Delhi's Connaught Place established in 1951 invokes nostalgia. As you climb up the steps to the first-floor store, you hear Lata Mangeshkar's crystal clear voice singing "*Lag ja gale ki phir...*" It's a vinyl record of a collection of her songs playing on a turntable. Everything about the whole set-up is very old school—just like the name of the store—rows and rows of vinyls, a couple of gramophones, several turntables—except for the customers. Rajul Yadav, 31, and Shikha Sinha, 29, became vinyl heads—a term used to describe those obsessed with the analogue medium—during the pandemic when a friend introduced them to records. "Once you go analogue you don't go back," laughs Sinha who works in a Delhi-based publishing house. Agrees Yadav, an HR manager in a global firm: "The quality of music on analogue is so superior that I can't bring myself to listen to the same song on Spotify anymore."

While vinyl records may seem like a relic of a time gone by, they are making a comeback and are attracting an increasingly younger audience. At Radio & Gramophone House, between 25 and 30 per cent of the customers are in their 30s or below, says Sunil Jain, the proprietor. The store, which sells digital players, Bluetooth speakers, stereo systems and all things electronic, gets nearly 70 per cent of its sales from records and turntables, says Jain.

It's the same story across the



1

GLOBALLY, THE VINYL MARKET IN 2021 AND IS EXPECTED TO REACH \$2.6 BILLION BY 2027, AT A CAGR OF 8.4 PER CENT, ACCORDING TO A REPORT BY MARKET RESEARCH FIRM IMARC.

country at Mumbai's Revolver Club, a vinyl store established in 2017. "There are two types of collectors: either those who have already been collecting... these are typically older people with access to more disposable income. The second is the younger generation that is seeing more references to records in pop culture. A large number of TV shows today have a reference to a turntable or record. Younger people are being exposed to records, encouraging them to get into the hobby," says 35-year-old Jude de Souza, Founder of the Revolver Club. Nearly 40 per cent of his clientele is Gen Z, and he sells between 800-1,000 records a month. "There's definitely a revival of the record. We are growing nearly 100 per cent year-on-year," says de Souza.

Globally the vinyl market

size was \$1.5 billion in 2021 and is expected to reach \$2.6 billion by 2027, at a CAGR of 8.4 per cent, as per a report by market research firm IMARC.

Nehal Shah, a self-confessed vinyl lover, set up India Record Co.—an online store for all things analogue—in November 2020. "The image of a vinyl collector used to be a 50-plus man sitting with his whisky and cigar, dropping the needle and listening to slow jazz music. That whole thing is changing now. The younger generation is looking at vinyl as a medium to connect with the artist and bring the artist home. It is pure music, no ads, no screen, no algorithms," she says. Nearly 45 per cent of Shah's buyers are below 30 and while maximum demand comes from Bengaluru, she also has customers in Ranchi,